24: The Ultimate Script

By Dave Barry

NARRATOR: **(Pgs 127-156)** *6 A.M. -- THE WHITE HOUSE SITUATION ROOM -- The president, seen only in silhouette, sits at the head of a conference table. Seated around the table are the vice president, the Joint Chiefs of Staff, and various important-looking extras. The lighting is dim.*

INTRODUCTION

Personally, I gave up on 24 during the second season, when Jack Bauer's daughter was menaced by a cougar, but the show lasted a blockbuster eight years. Or, in show terms, eight days. See each episode only covers 1 clock hour in Bauer's rather mundane life . . . Each season shows only 1 24-hour day . . . Eight years = 8 days. . . but over those eight days secret agent Jack Bauer had to use a lot of excessive force to save the country. How much excessive force? He killed ***TWO HUNDRED SIXTY-SEVEN PEOPLE*** *in eight days. In case you haven't seen the series . . . I've prepared a trailer for you . . . 1 hour in less than 10 minutes! Move over Chuck Norris, the new man of the house is Jack Bauer.*

This is . . . 24: The Ultimate Script by Dave Barry

THE PRESIDENT: I've called you together because we have received intelligence concerning a serious threat that could . . . What is it, Mr. Vice President?

THE VICE PRESIDENT: Why is the lighting so dim?

THE PRESIDENT: For dramatic effect. You'll also notice that many characters in this show whisper for no good reason.

THE VICE PRESIDENT: *(peering at the president)* Wait a minute. You're a kangaroo.

THE PRESIDENT: Yes. The writers already did an African-American president and a woman president, so this season they were thinking, "Maybe a Jewish president?" And then they thought, "Nah, too unrealistic." So they went kangaroo. . . As I was saying, we have received intelligence concerning a threat that could cause the deaths of millions of Americans.

FBI DIRECTOR: We have reason to believe that a vaguely Middle Eastern terrorist organization has acquired a proton defrackulator.

THE PRESIDENT: What's a proton defrackulator?

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FBI DIRECTOR: We have no idea. But it sounds very bad.

THE PRESIDENT: Well, if these terrorists think I'm going to let them kill millions of Americans on my watch just because I have short, thumbless forelimbs, then they have another think coming. General, what do the Joint Chiefs recommend?

GENERAL: We recommend an immediate tactical nuclear missile strike against Boston.

THE PRESIDENT: Is that where the terrorists are?

GENERAL: No, we just hate Boston.

THE PRESIDENT: Fair enough. But we also need to do something about these terrorists.

CHIEF OF STAFF: There is only one man who can stop these terrorists, and that man is Jack Bauer.

THE PRESIDENT: Bauer . . . I know that name.

CHIEF OF STAFF: He's the main character.

THE PRESIDENT: Ah, right. But didn't he end the last season being arrested on trumped-up charges after he was framed by a shadowy cabal of powerful men?

CHIEF OF STAFF: That's how he ends every season.

THE PRESIDENT: So where is Bauer now?

CHIEF OF STAFF: Imprisoned in a secret California prison facility.

THE PRESIDENT: Have him released.

CHIEF OF STAFF: He was also tortured, decapitated and fed to boars.

THE PRESIDENT: Whoa.

CHIEF OF STAFF: Fortunately, he was trained for exactly that.

THE PRESIDENT: Are you saying that he could . . .

NARRATOR: *SETTING: THE INFIRMARY OF A SECRET CALIFORNIA PRISON -- Jack Bauer is sitting on an examination table. There are boar bites all over his body and a bandage wrapped around his neck. A doctor has just finished examining him.*

DOCTOR: You're going to experience some soreness from having your head reattached to your body. I suggest you take it easy for at least the next hour.

JACK: Give me your phone.

DOCTOR: If you need to make a call, there's a phone in the-

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JACK: Dammit, there's NO TIME!

NARRATOR: *Jack pulls a gun and shoots the doctor in the thigh. As the doctor falls to the floor, Jack snatches his cell phone and dials a number. The scene shifts to an FBI office in Washington, D.C., where Chloe, sitting at her computer, answers the phone.*

CHLOE: Hello?

JACK: Chloe, it's Jack.

CHLOE: Jack? I thought you were decapitated and consumed by boars.

JACK: Not anymore. A terrorist cell is bringing in a proton defrackulator. I need a map showing the port of entry for every international freight shipment in the past thirteen days weighing between fifty-two and sixty-three kilograms, overlaid with another grid showing the locations of all metropolitan areas with populations of twenty-eight thousand or more, overlaid with another grid showing prevailing wind direction and speed, overlaid with another grid showing the location of every odd-numbered Waffle House in North America.

CHLOE *(tapping keyboard)* Sending it now.

JACK: *(checks his cell phone)* They're bringing the defrackulator into the Washington area.

CHLOE: That makes sense. All the other main characters are here.

JACK: *(stepping over the doctor to the exit)* I'll need transport.

CHLOE: *(tapping)* I'll send a helicopter.

JACK: *(runs outside. A helicopter immediately appears overhead)* I have a visual. Have the FBI set up a perimeter around Washington, Maryland, and Virginia. Don't let anybody in or out. Shut down the shipping lanes and set up satellite surveillance to detect anybody on the Eastern Seaboard who looks vaguely Middle Eastern.

CHLOE: *(tapping)* I'm on it.

NARRATOR: *Jack runs to the helicopter, shoots the pilot in the thigh, throws him out of the chopper, grabs the controls, and takes off. SETTING: A SEAPORT - Two vaguely Middle Eastern-looking terrorists are watching as a crane lowers a wooden crate from a freighter to the pier.*

FIRST TERRORIST: Once the proton defrackulator is loaded into the van, we'll take it to our secret hideout in Washington.

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SECOND TERRORIST: Then we will activate it and carry out the plan to kill millions of Americans.

FIRST TERRORIST: You should roll your "r"s, so our accents sound more alike. *(pulls out a cell phone and dials a number)* I have the floral centerpiece and will deliver it to the wedding reception. *(ends the call)*

SECOND TERRORIST: Was that a coded message to the terrorist mastermind?

FIRST TERRORIST: No, that was my brother-in-law, the florist. I'm helping him out with a wedding.

SECOND TERRORIST: Let's get going, then. Those millions of Americans aren't going to kill themselves!

NARRATOR: *The two men enjoy a vaguely Middle Eastern laugh, shoot the dockworkers, get into the van, and drive away. SETTING: INSIDE THE HELICOPTER - Jack is at the controls. The phone rings. He plugs a Bluetooth headset into his ear.*

JACK: Jack Bauer.

CHLOE: Jack, we just got satellite recon video showing unusual activity at the Chevy Chase seaport. Two men took possession of a crate exactly the size of a proton defrackulator, loaded it into a van, and took off. Also they shot all the dockworkers.

JACK: Hmm. Were they swarthy?

CHLOE: *(tapping)* I'm uploading a photo.

JACK: *(looking at phone)* Those are terrorists, all right. Do you have a visual on the van?

CHLOE: *(taping)* Yes. The van stopped at a wedding reception to deliver a floral centerpiece.

JACK: Copy that. Where's the van now?

CHLOE: It's heading toward the Department of Commerce building in downtown Washington on Old Plankton Road.

JACK: Keep me posted. I'm landing at the White House now.

NARRATOR: *The chopper lands on the White House lawn. Jack jumps out, shoots a Marine attempting to salute him, and strides into the White House. An instant later he enters the Situation Room.*

THE PRESIDENT: Mr. Bauer, thank you for . . . Whoa, are those boar bites?

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JACK: There was also an ocelot. I'll be fine.

THE PRESIDENT: Ouch. Anyway, thank you for coming from California in eight minutes. Jack, what do you know about the plot?

JACK: The terrorists brought the proton defrackulator in through the Chevy Chase seaport and are heading into Washington on Old Plankton Road. I'll need a tactical assault team of extras headed by an attractive woman.

THE PRESIDENT: Done.

JACK: Also I may have to blow up the Department of Commerce. Apparently it's a terrorist hideout.

THE PRESIDENT: I wondered what they did in there.

NARRATOR: *SETTING: DOWNTOWN WASHINGTON, D.C. - Jack lands the helicopter outside the Department of Commerce Building.*

JACK: *(into phone)* Chloe, I need the building schematics now.

CHLOE: *(tapping furiously)* Here are the schematics.

JACK: *(frowning)* According to these, we can enter the building by. . . the door.

CHLOE: Jack, there's something else. I just ran a cross-modulated algorithm series on the HEPCOM database, and for shocking-plot twist reasons that make no logical sense, your son is in that building.

JACK: I have a son?

CHLOE: Apparently this season you do.

JACK: We need to get to the proton defrackulator before the terrorists activate it.

NARRATOR: *Jack runs into the building, met in the lobby by a hail of bullets. Many extras go down. Jack pulls a pistol and fires approximately eight hundred shots, each of which kills an enemy gunman. But more gunmen keep appearing. Jack crouches behind a lamp. Tens of thousands of bullets ricochet around him.*

JACK: *(shouting into a Bluetooth headset)* Chloe, we're pinned down by hostiles in the Department of Commerce!

CHLOE: I wondered what they did in there.

JACK: *(shouting)* I need the location of the defrackulator!

CHLOE: *(tapping)* It's in the basement, next to the National Aquarium.

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JACK: Why is the National Aquarium in the Commerce Department Building?

CHLOE: *(tapping)* Nobody knows. Jack, there's something else. They've put your son into the octopus tank.

NARRATOR: *Through a blizzard of bullets, Jack runs across the lobby, killing people en route. He runs into an elevator, which contains fourteen hostile gunmen. The door closes. As the elevator descends, Jack and the gunmen engage in a fierce gunfight, during which he kills them all. The door opens and Jack stumbles out of the elevator into the basement.*

JACK: *(shouting into headset)* Which way?

CHLOE: *(tapping)* To the right! Hurry, Jack!

NARRATOR: *Jack runs to his right. Ahead is the aquarium tank; inside it, in the grasp of an octopus, is a young man, played by Keanu Reeves. Next to the tank is one of the terrorists, doing something to what looks like a large espresso machine.*

JACK: *(aiming gun)* Step away from the defrackulator NOW!

TERRORIST: You're too late, Bauer!

NARRATOR: *As Jack looks toward his son, Chloe's voice shouts in his earpiece.*

CHLOE: Jack! Look out behind you!

NARRATOR: *Jack starts to turn, but he's too late. The second terrorist leaps from a hallway with a machete and whacks Jack's head off.*

CHLOE: Jack! Are you all right?

JACK'S HEAD: *(on floor)* I'll be fine.

FIRST TERRORIST: *(pushing a button)* The proton defrackulator has been activated!

JACK'S HEAD: What does it do, anyway?

FIRST TERRORIST: We actually don't know. But we assume it's bad.

NARRATOR: *The camera zooms in on the proton defrackulator to reveal a digital timer counting down . . . 15 . . . 14 . . . 13 . . .*

JACK BAUER'S VOICE: Following are scenes from next week's 24.

NARRATOR: *SETTING: THE WHITE HOUSE SITUATION ROOM*

CHIEF OF STAFF: Madam President, Newark is gone.

THE PRESIDENT: Newark, New Jersey, or Newark, Delaware?

CHIEF OF STAFF: What difference does it make?

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THE PRESIDENT: Good point! *(Everybody enjoys a hearty laugh)*

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AWARD HISTORY

2011 National Qualifier
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